The Interaction of Economic Inequality and Authoritarianism on Voter Preference During the 2016 Presidential Election

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Introduction

The voting behavior of the U.S. public in the 2016 Presidential election between Hillary Clinton and Donald J. Trump will be extensively analyzed by psychologists and political scientists to grasp the complex factors that led to a surprising election result.

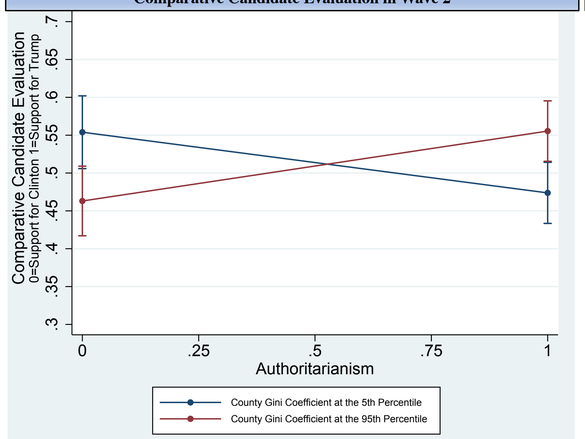
Prior research suggests that individuals in the United States are sorting themselves into political parties based on personality predispositions like authoritarianism, which can be activated by perceived threat (Hetherington & Weiler, 2009). If this dynamic relationship between personality and environment is playing out in the 2016 Presidential election, this research could give further external validity to these theories.

Research has yet to explore contextual variables reflecting the environment having a possible interactive relationship with personality predispositions, like authoritarianism, on vote preference (Trump vs. Clinton) in the 2016 Presidential election.

I hypothesized the effect of personality on voting behavior will be different based on varying levels of the environment, including racial diversity or economic outcomes. For example, in areas of high racial diversity, high authoritarians will prefer Trump and low authoritarians will prefer Clinton. In areas of low racial diversity, there will be no relationship between authoritarianism and voter preference.

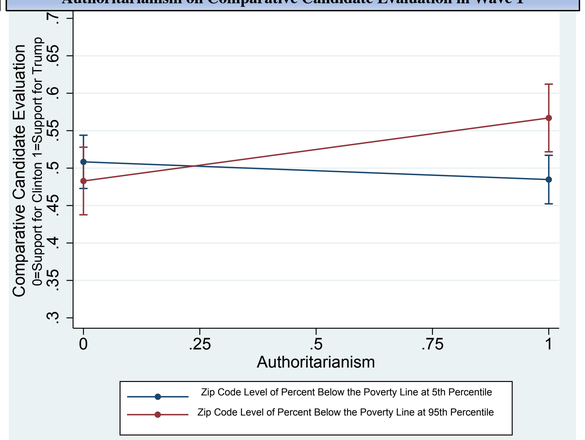
Results

The Interaction of the County-Level Gini Coefficient and Authoritarianism on Comparative Candidate Evaluation in Wave 2



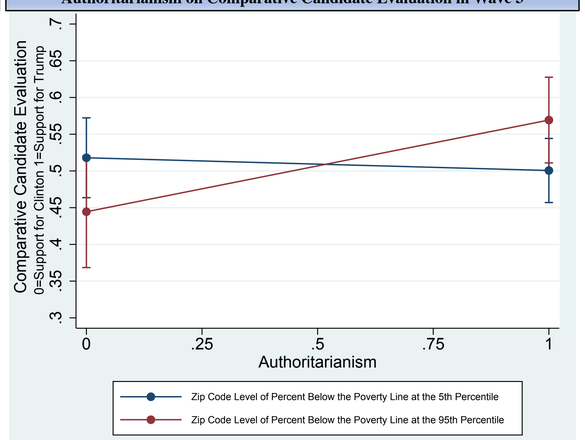
A regression analysis indicated a statistically significant interaction between authoritarianism and the county-level Gini coefficient on CCE at Wave 2 ($N = 679$; $F_{(14, 664)} = 175.45$, $p = 0.008$). The regression coefficients can be interpreted as percent change in CCE since all the variables are recoded on a 0-1 scale. Wave 1 CCE was controlled for in this model so the effect indicated is change in CCE between July (Wave 1) and September (Wave 2).

The Interaction of the Zip-Code Level of Percent Below the Poverty Line and Authoritarianism on Comparative Candidate Evaluation in Wave 1



A separate regression analysis indicated a statistically significant interaction between authoritarianism and the zip-code level of percent below the poverty line on CCE at Wave 1 ($N = 1{,}267$; $F_{(9, 1257)} = 195.01$, $p = 0.053$).

The Interaction of the Zip-Code Level of Percent Below the Poverty Line and Authoritarianism on Comparative Candidate Evaluation in Wave 3



A regression analysis indicated a statistically significant interaction between authoritarianism and the zip-code level of percent below the poverty line on CCE at Wave 3 ($N = 315$; $F_{(10, 304)} = 148.46$, $p = 0.089$). Wave 2 CCE was controlled for in this model so the effect indicated is change in CCE between September (Wave 2) and October (Wave 3).

Methods

Participants

The participants were recruited by the Center for the Study of Political Psychology's Presidential Election Study (CSPP-PEPS), a survey that took place over the course of the 2016 election cycle. Participants were able to take part in 4 waves of the survey, with built-in attrition. Wave 1 was July 2016 , Wave 2 was September 2016, Wave 3 was October 2016, and Wave 4 was November 2016 after the election.

Procedure

STATA-Data Analysis Software was used to analyze the interaction of authoritarianism and contextual variables, that reflect the environment of the individuals taking part of the CSPP-PEPS survey, using regression models when measuring comparative candidate evaluations (CCE). Controlling for the prior Wave's CCE score allowed the models to show the change in candidate evaluations over time, as well as relative to each other.

Measures

Waves 1, 2, and 3 used CCE as the dependent variable, which was generated by feeling thermometers that all respondents used to rate their feelings of the candidates on a scale of 0 to 100. Authoritarianism scores were generated using four child rearing questions that respondents answered in Wave 1.

Contextual variables used in interaction with authoritarianism were the county-level Gini coefficient and the zip-code level of percent below the poverty line. Both were generated using census data from 2015. All variables were recoded on a 0-1 scale.

Discussion

Regression analyses of the data in the 2016 CSPP-PEP shows evidence for the authoritarian dynamic having a limited effect during the 2016 Presidential election. Income inequality and poverty levels were the environmental variables that seem to activate the authoritarian personality predisposition. Models with racial diversity did not have any statistically significant interactions with authoritarianism.

In areas of low income inequality, as authoritarianism increased so too did support for Clinton. In areas low in poverty, there was no relationship between authoritarianism and CCE. However, in high poverty and high income inequality areas, as authoritarianism increased so too did support for Trump.

The authoritarian dynamic could have been activated by Trump's rhetoric about American economic strength and could have led to support for Trump in 2016 by high authoritarians. Trump spent a large amount of the campaign vowing to bring back manufacturing and coal jobs as well as impose tariffs to reduce supposed trade imbalance with Mexico and China. Trump also promised to take on Wall Street and was marketed as a business insider who could get the best deals for America.

Individuals high in authoritarianism could have interpreted this rhetoric as Trump bringing about a more even distribution of income and less poverty. The less socioeconomic difference exists in the environment, the less threat to the social fabric; thus individuals high in authoritarianism would have less anxiety about the makeup of society.

Implications and Future Research

Although this research shows broad trends of authoritarianism and environment, the relatively small marginal differences in change of support for either candidate in the 2016 Presidential election show that further research on this topic is necessary.

Implications for this research include the possibility of an increase in the sorting of the political parties by socioeconomic class. The candidate that uses rhetoric to assuage high authoritarians in areas of high income inequality will garner more support from these individuals. Language in political campaigns that emphasizes the threat of increasing income inequality and poverty will also win support of high authoritarians.

Future research using this paradigm could help to understand the complex interactive nature of authoritarianism and other personality predispositions. Prior research showing an increase in demographic shifts, racial diversity and income inequality point to this being an important topic for the future of political discourse (Craig & Richeson, 2014; Velez & Lavine, 2017).

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